

Session 19: How Jesus Destroyed Enmity

Key Takeaways

- In order for God to create the true family of Abraham, he needed to destroy the hostility between Israel and the nations and dethrone the powers.
- The point of the Torah's narrative is to expose humanity's inability to be God's faithful covenant partners (including those God first chose).
- According to Paul, the commands in the Torah are good and righteous, but they have also created death and hostility.

The Role of the Covenant: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 2:11-22

- A ¹¹ Therefore remember, that at one time y'all, the gentiles **in flesh**, who are called "uncircumcised" by what is called "the circumcised" (what is performed by hands **in the flesh**),
- B ¹² that y'all were at that time, without Messiah, **estranged** from the **citizenry of Israel**, and **foreigners** of the covenants of the promise, having no hope and **without God** in the world.
- C ¹³ But now, in Messiah Jesus, y'all who were at one time **far off** have become **near** by the blood of the Messiah. ¹⁴ For he himself is our **peace**,
- D the one who made **the two into one**, and having destroyed the barrier of the wall, **the enmity**, ¹⁵ in his flesh,
- having set aside the Torah of commandments in decrees, in order that he might create in himself **the two into one** new humanity, making **peace**,
- ¹⁶ and that he might reconcile to God **the two by means of one body**, through the cross, having killed **the enmity** in himself.

C'

17 And as he came, he announced good news of **peace** to y'all who are **far off**, and peace to those **near**, 18 because through him we both, by means of one Spirit, have access to the Father.

B'

19 Therefore then, y'all are no longer **foreigners and immigrants**, but y'all are **fellow citizens of the holy ones** and **household members of God**,

A'

20 having been built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, the cornerstone being Messiah Jesus himself, 21 in whom the entire building is joined together, so that it can grow into a holy temple **in the Lord**, 22 in whom y'all too are being built together into a dwelling-building of God, **in the Spirit**.

Ephesians 2:11-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

This entire paragraph is designed as a symmetrical flow of thought, where each section contrasts with its partners.

- A and A': They used to be outsiders based "in the flesh," but now they are part of the messianic new temple in the Lord/in the Spirit.
- B and B': They were once estranged, foreigners, and without God, but now they are fellow citizens and members of God's family.
- C and C': They were once far off, but now they are brought near.
- D and D' and D'': The two that were separated have become one in the Messiah.

Flow of Thought in 2:11-22

Ephesians 2:11-12 *Past Reality*: Gentiles were not a part of the covenant family of Israel nor covenantally related to the creator.

Ephesians 2:13 *Present Reality*: The Gentiles who were once far from Yahweh have been "brought near" by the agency of "the blood of the Messiah."

- Key Question: How does the death (blood) of Israel's Messiah bring non-Israelites into the covenant family of Israel?

Ephesians 2:14-16: The Messiah has made Jewish and Gentile people one unified family of God by:

- Tearing down the dividing wall, the enmity in his flesh
- Nullifying the Torah consisting of commands in decrees

Ephesians 2:17-22: Jews and Gentiles are united by the Messiah as family members of God's household (οἰκεῖοι), which constitutes the new temple building (οἰκοδομῇ) anticipated by Israel's Scriptures.

- Hebrew Bible anticipations of a new temple (Ezek. 40-48; Joel 3:17-18; Zech. 6:12-15)

- New Testament realization of that temple as Jesus' followers (1 Cor. 3:16-17, 6:19; Eph. 2:19-22; 1 Pet. 2:4-9)
 - Note: Paul combines the metaphors of the temple building (apostles/prophets as the foundation, believers as bricks, and Jesus as the cornerstone) and a tree ("grows into a sanctuary"), which is reminiscent of Psalm 1.

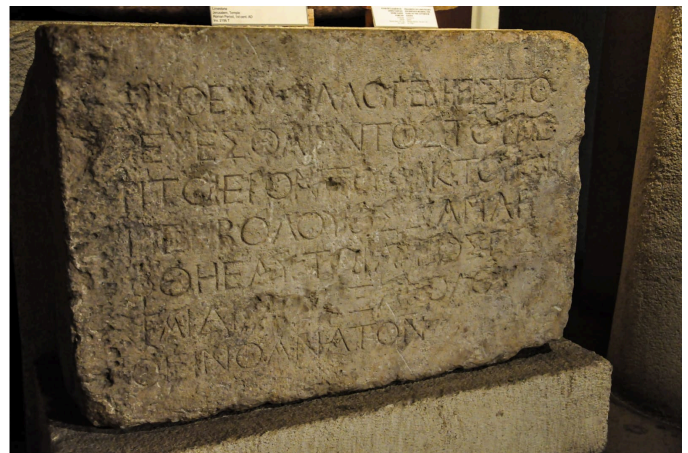
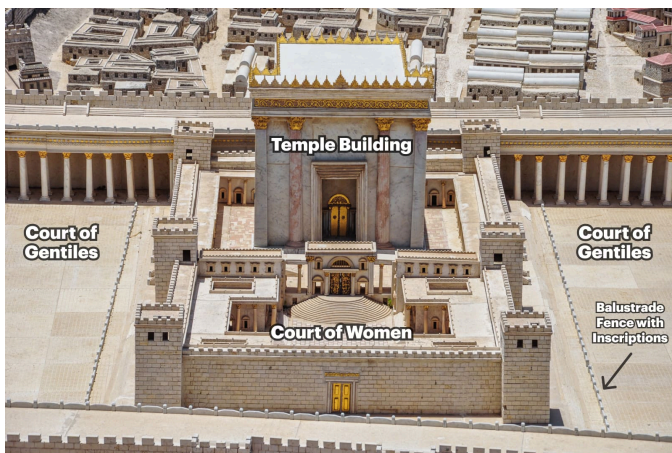
Key Interpretive Issues in 2:11-22

There are two interpretive questions that shape our understanding of what Paul is explaining in this passage.

1. What is the dividing wall, and how did Jesus' death ("in his flesh") take it down?
2. What does it mean that Jesus nullified the Torah, and what is the Torah's relationship to the torn down dividing wall in the previous line?

View 1

The dividing wall refers to the barrier wall that stood in the court of the Jerusalem temple with a sign.



Left Image: Rasmussen, Carol. (2010). *Zondervan Atlas of the Bible* (Revised Edition). Zondervan. Page 202. HolyLandPhotos.org. Right Image: Rasmussen, Carol. (2010). *Zondervan Atlas of the Bible* (Revised Edition). Zondervan. Page 221. HolyLandPhotos.org.

Pros of View 1

The following context refers to the new messianic temple, where Jews and Gentiles together are the new temple and have access to the Father through the same Spirit.

- [A] He is himself our peace
 - [B] the one who made the two groups into one,
 - [C] having torn down the dividing wall of hostility in his flesh
 - [C'] having nullified the Torah consisting of commands in decrees
 - [B'] in order to create the two groups into one new humanity,
- [A'] making peace.

Cons of View 1

Paul cannot assume that many (or perhaps any) of his Gentile readers in Asia Minor have been to the Jerusalem temple and know what he is talking about. At the time of Paul's writing this letter (in the 50s C.E.), the barrier still stood. The grammar, syntax, and rhetorical design of the sentence leads one to identify that the "wall" and the "Torah" refer to the same thing.

View 2

The dividing wall is a vivid metaphor to describe the paradoxical role of the Torah in God's purpose. In Ephesians 2:14-16, Paul is condensing his longer and more complex discussions of this point from Galatians 3 and Romans 7-8.

Progression of the Role of the Torah in the Story of the Bible

1. God gave humanity the first command in the garden (Gen. 2:15), and this was seized upon by "sin/snake," which worked a deception precisely through the command and resulted in human rebellion. God exiled the rebels and handed them over to exile and death.
2. God said that a promised seed would arrive to defeat the sin/snake precisely through a mortal wound by the sin/ snake (Gen. 3:15).
3. God called Abraham and his seed to live by covenant faithfulness, and after delivering Israel from slavery in Egypt, he gave them the "Torah of commands" to make clear the terms of the covenant. Obedience to the covenant will bring life and blessing to all of the nations. And disobedience will bring exile and death and further hostility with the nations.
4. Israel goes on to violate the covenant, and their seed is handed over to exile and death. The good laws of the Torah, designed to bring blessing on Israel and the nations, were hijacked by the sin/snake so that they brought death (just like in the garden story).
5. Israel's Messiah became the covenant representative of Israel and the priestly representative of all humanity by being faithful to the terms of the covenant. However, he also died as a cursed violator of the covenant on behalf of all violators so that his resurrection life could be shared with all those who offer believing loyalty to him, thereby participating in his own life. (For this complicated but coherent line of thought, see Gal. 3:6-28 and Rom. 7-8, specifically Rom. 8:3-4).
6. After the resurrection of Jesus and the gift of the Spirit, the laws of the Torah are no longer the defining criteria for membership in the covenant family of Abraham. This includes the laws that separated Israel from the nations (kosher diet, circumcision, Sabbath). The defining marker of membership is believing loyalty to Jesus and his Father, which opens up God's family to people of all nations so that they can become the new temple.

“‘Barrier’ is the word used in the Septuagint for the protective hedge which God planted around Israel, his vineyard (Isa. 5:2). In Isaiah's parable, it is God who breaks down the hedge around Israel and leaves it exposed to devastation because of Israel's faithlessness. In the period of the Second Temple and later in the time of the Rabbis, Jews sometimes spoke of the Torah as a protective hedge which protected Israel from sin. In the Letter of Aristeas (v. 139) we read that Moses by the gift of the Torah 'hedged us about with impregnable ramparts and iron walls, to prevent all contact with any of the other nations, and to keep us pure in body and soul, free from futile speculations, worshipping the one Almighty God above the creation.' Paul's point ... is that the Torah, intended by God to be a protective hedge, has been turned by Israelite

nationalism into a cultural system that has totally isolated Israel from the Gentile world and is thus responsible for the hostility between Jew and Gentile. Only by the annulment of the legal code could the barrier be removed, and Paul says this was done 'in his flesh.' Paul is claiming (1) that Jesus deliberately drew off onto himself the hostility between Torah observant Jews and those Gentiles whose company they avoided, and (2) that this hostility brought him to the cross, and (3) that because he refused to return the hostility, it died there with him. This is a picture substantially borne out by the Gospel narratives, and for Paul the verification of it was plainly to be seen in any Pauline church, where Jew and Gentile mixed freely on equal terms."

Caird, G.B. (1977). [*Paul's Letters From Prison*](#). Oxford University Press. 58-59.

Reflection Question

The Torah tells the story of God choosing a family, redeeming them from slavery, and giving them commands for how to relate with him and others. Unfortunately, this family continually fails to be faithful to God and his commands, leading to violence and death. With this in mind, summarize the purpose of the Torah in a few sentences.